



Fedora 14

I'm Smiling About Laughlin

On November 2, this year, the Fedora Project released version 14 of its wildly popular GNU/Linux distribution. I've been eagerly awaiting a bug-free KDE, well-packaged by a distro, especially since KDE became usable again with version 4.3. I had an uncanny feeling that Fedora 14, code-named Laughlin, would be it—and it was! So this review is mostly about KDE, but there is a bit about GNOME, Fedora's default desktop environment.

I was initially a KDE user, but for a long time, I've been using GNOME on Ubuntu. This is because there has always been some serious bug or the other in KDE, ever since the team overhauled the desktop. I have waited with eager anticipation for a bug-free KDE and a distro that would serve it in a nice package, but have had no luck. Even when KDE became usable again with version 4.3, no distro did it right. But when Fedora released version 14 on 2nd November, I had an uncanny feeling that *this* would be the distro I was waiting for. Yes, it was!

However, what bowled me over first was not KDE—it was the new Fedora website. Never have I seen such an outstanding presentation of free and open source software, or of an operating system, done so meticulously. Even if FOSS is not your cup of tea, it may succeed in wooing you. The interesting part is that if you are already a FOSS supporter, it will make you smile for all the right reasons, and that's not

something you come across every day.

Anyway, I immediately downloaded the 64-bit KDE spin. There is KDE 4.5.2 with a custom Fedora theme called Laughlin, after the release codename, and it's beautiful (see Figure 1). The login and splash screens are the most beautiful ever. All hardware worked, including the Broadcom 4312 wireless chip, using the driver from RPM Fusion, although I did have to install `b43-tools` and `rkill` as well. I don't have any other hardware that requires proprietary drivers. The multimedia codecs provided by RPM Fusion also worked correctly. KPackageKit, the software manager, is now much more usable, and shows package groups on the home screen (see Figure 2), as well as icons for the installed applications (see Figure 3).

KDE itself has also improved significantly. The calendar shows local holidays (as in Figure 4), while Dolphin, the file manager, has enhanced Nepomuk support for semantic desktop integration (take a look at Figure 5). However, one of the really thoughtful design decisions